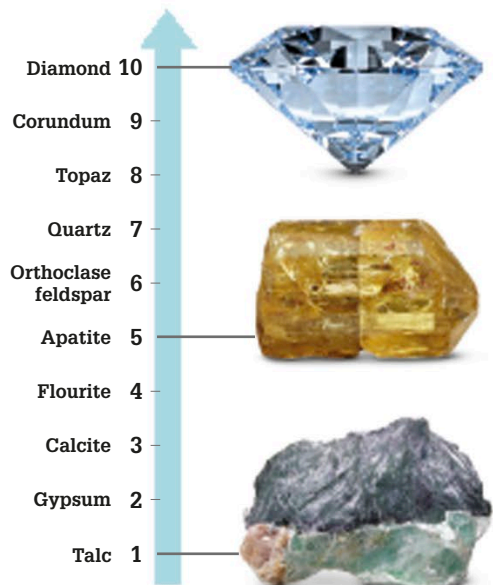




The Mohs scale of mineral hardness

1812

Mohs scale

German geologist Friedrich Mohs created a scale for classifying minerals based on their hardness. On this scale, consisting of ten standard minerals, diamond is the hardest mineral and talc the softest. Geologists still use the Mohs scale today.

1815

1813

Getting up steam

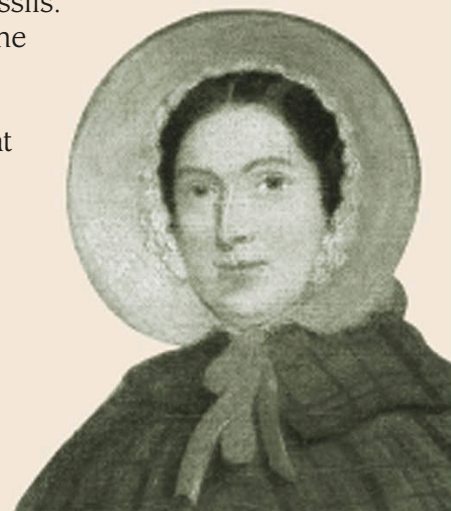
Locomotives – steam engines that moved as opposed to those that were fixed – were now being used to pull heavy loads in mines and quarries. *Puffing Billy*, the oldest surviving steam locomotive in the world, was built in 1813 to pull coal trucks at a mine in northern England. It remained in service until 1865, and is now preserved in London's Science Museum.



The story of engines
See pages 130–131

1799–1847 MARY ANNING

The daughter of a carpenter, Mary Anning lived in Lyme Regis, a town on southern England's "Jurassic coast," an area rich in fossils. She was only 11 when she found and dug out the complete skeleton of an ichthyosaur, a reptile that swam in the sea in the age of the dinosaurs.



KEY DATES

1823 Anning found her first plesiosaur fossil, which brought her international fame.

1828 She discovered the skeleton of a pterosaur, a flying reptile.

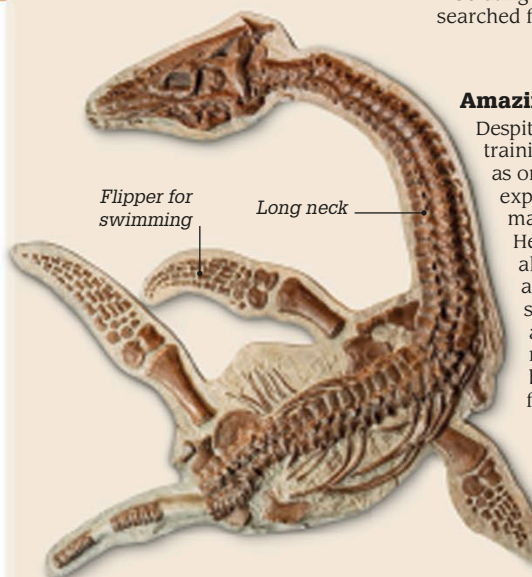
1838 She was awarded an annual grant by the British Association for the Advancement of Science.

Fossil hunter

Anning had no formal education, as women were barred from academic life, but had an impressive understanding of her subject. The idea of extinct creatures was groundbreaking and she made a living as a fossil hunter, selling fossils she had found to both private collectors and museums. However, the work could be dangerous as the cliffs where she searched for fossils were unstable and liable to collapse.

Amazing finds

Despite having no formal training, Anning was recognized as one of the leading fossil experts of the day. She made many significant discoveries. Her most famous find was the almost complete skeleton of a plesiosaur, thought to be a sort of "sea dragon." It was actually a large marine reptile with a broad, flat body, long neck, and four flippers.



Plesiosaur fossil discovered by Mary Anning

“The carpenter’s daughter has won a name for herself, and has deserved to win it.”

Writer Charles Dickens in an article about Mary Anning, 1865